‘But it was Tamil Nadu that first proposed the constitution of the Cauvery Tribunal, in 1986. The tribunal was formed in 1990, after so much effort put in by the state. All that hard work cannot go in vain,’ said Chest Number 16.

‘Kaveri is the lifeblood of both, Karnataka and Tamil Nadu. I think the governments of both the states should be allowed an equal part in its share and control,’ Chest Number 99 said.

‘But Karnataka has ceased supply of water to Tamil Nadu,’ Chest Number 68 said.

The discussion, which had turned into a debate, went on for another two minutes as I listened. But time pressed on and I realized that if I didn’t speak now, I would have to pay for it heavily. Not knowing which state to side with, I made an entirely different point when I barged in and said, ‘Why should any state be given control of a resource that belongs to the country?’ To my surprise, all the candidates went silent for a split second and before anyone could start again, I continued, ‘It should be a nation’s responsibility to take care of its waters. Every state government will think of its own benefit, and we have been witnessing this since Independence. That is why Karnataka rejected the tribunal award in 1991. And Tamil Nadu has been resisting the building of dams by Karnataka while it continues to build its own. The Kaveri is not a state’s property—it is a nation’s resource.’

‘But the Central government, too, has never provided a reasonable solution,’ Chest Number 68 countered.

‘You may be right,’ I said, and continued, ‘the Central government alone cannot find a solution. We, as a nation, have to come together on this matter. Agencies, like power corporations and even small-scale industries that use its water, should be made accountable and responsible for its maintenance. The flow of water should depend on the quarterly results of this upkeep and careful calculation of a state’s predicted requirements. Everyone who uses the Kaveri’s waters must be bound to a uniform code to avoid exploitation of the river, and to minimize water pollution. After all, who must rightly control the river-water flow isn’t the question—rather, we